

bodyTime()

In `bodyTime()`, André Clements extends a practice shaped by regular life-drawing sessions into a collection of double-exposure photographs. Each work arises from an unpressured commitment to consent, an implicit understanding that fosters vulnerability as a gentle offering rather than a performance. Artist and subject share a quiet balance—each holds firm to personal boundaries, turning raw presence into a mutual act of trust.

The black-and-white images hint at an object-oriented ontology, where no element—person, pose, or viewer—claims dominance. Forms merge briefly, presence and absence weaving into a layered gesture that whispers of non-duality. Priced at a whimsical R3,333.33, the works defy market norms, echoing the unadorned simplicity of the life-drawing space.

Soft shadows and overlapping lines within these frames reveal the human form as fleeting—an echo of a moment slipped by. This impermanence underscores a dedication to openness and respect: each subject remains its own, free from the grip of the gaze or fixed story. Here, vulnerability becomes a deliberate reclaiming of power, a subtle path to authenticity shared by those who step forward. `bodyTime()` offers a pause, a still moment where attention, presence, and consent meet—and then, softly, fade.

bodyTime()

In bodyTime(), André Clements brings the calm feeling from sessions of drawing people into black-and-white photos.

The photos mix two moments. Everyone says, “I’m okay, no pressure.” This helps the artist and the person posing trust each other. They respect space. A “yes” makes a friendship.

In these pictures, no one leads. The pictures show what is there and not there, like a shadow in the sun.

Each photo costs R3,333.33. This fun price does not follow normal art prices, like the easy drawing sessions.

Soft shadows and lines show time moves. Each person stands free. No one’s look or story holds them. Being open is their choice. It makes them feel strong. bodyTime() stops for a moment. It asks you to look and feel. Then it fades—like a breath.

bodyTime()

Saying Yes, Softly

A small group gathers in my studio for a few hours. It's been this way regularly since 2017: just a handful of artists and a someone who will pose, sometimes friends, sometimes strangers, all sorts of bodies, all sorts of lives. We begin not by drawing, not by positioning, but by checking in gently: "How's everyone today?"—model included, always. There's a moment of quiet recognition, simple consent to share this space. No assumptions, no roles forced upon anyone—just a soft yes, freely given, freely received.

In that moment, something quietly shifts. Layers of everyday pretense soften and dissolve. We move gently into presence—no forcing, no pushing, just being there, together. Time slows; the body settles. This gentle space is about more than art—it's a subtle invitation to authenticity, to vulnerability offered without exposure, to honesty emerging not from pressure but from permission.

That's where bodyTime() begins. Not as an abstract idea, nor some grand claim to absolute truth, but simply as an extension of these regular encounters, this familiar, shared humanness. bodyTime() quietly carries that same energy into a collection of gentle black-and-white double-exposure photographs, softly layered, shown briefly at Stokvel Gallery, for only two days. Each piece is priced playfully at R3,333.33—not market logic, just shapes and curves that feel right.

But more deeply, bodyTime() offers something else—a gentle exploration of how we meet each other and ourselves, how we handle power, how we say yes to vulnerability without becoming victims or heroes or saviours. This space we create through life-drawing—soft, consensual, honest—quietly opposes the noisy, often hidden drama of everyday interactions. That exhausting cycle of victimhood, blame, and forced rescue—what psychologists call the Karpman Drama Triangle—is diffused simply by our careful consent. No one takes power from another here. Power is never truly shared, only taken or relinquished—but here we invite each other softly to take only our own power, no more, no less.

Vulnerability within consent becomes something gently profound. The difference between vulnerability freely offered and vulnerability taken is subtle but essential. Without consent, vulnerability becomes mere exposure, harsh and unsafe. But within clear consent, vulnerability opens softly, beautifully, honestly. It becomes safe precisely because it is freely chosen. This is the gentle thread running through bodyTime(): consent as the quiet heartbeat that makes honesty safe, makes vulnerability beautiful, makes authenticity possible.

Honesty, in this space, quietly dismantles the drama that often dominates life. No pretense, no masks, no hurried performance. It becomes integrity—a quiet resistance, gentle defiance against a louder world often built on domination and coercion. This integrity aligns softly with the Vita-Socio-Anarco ethos, which values life, community, and non-domination over control, competition, or profit. Integrity isn't moral superiority; it's a quiet choice—sometimes successful, sometimes failing, always striving toward authenticity.

This gentle rebellion shows itself subtly in the consistent pricing of my work—always R3,333.33, an absurdity. It's playfulness, quiet defiance, a softly spoken resistance. Stokvel Gallery resonates with this ethos perfectly. Founded by Gordon Froud, it's artist-run, commission-free, raw walls, simple lights—nothing grandiose, no hidden agendas. It mirrors the quiet humility of the life-drawing space, a gentle invitation extended to everyone equally, softly, honestly.

But bodyTime() also invites us to reconsider the way we see, the way we look. Philosopher Martha Nussbaum offers the nuanced possibility of non-pathological objectification—a respectful gaze, intimate yet non-invasive, possible only with clear consent. Consider images like 20241101_1 (Toe)—a foot, a breast softly dissolving—or 20231201_3 (Dancer)—a dancer suspended gently between stillness and movement. The gaze in these works isn't about possession, but quiet recognition. Intimacy without invasion, openness without forced exposure. Consent, again, makes this gentle exchange possible.

Gender freedom subtly emerges here too, quietly dismantling rigid stereotypes. bodyTime(), our life-drawing sessions, and the spaces around them intentionally reject binary assumptions or fixed roles. Bodies are simply bodies; people simply people. Everyone steps forward as themselves, without needing permission to be anything other than what they naturally, authentically are. There's no loud activism here—just quiet inclusion, subtle equality, gentle openness.

All of this—consent, vulnerability, honesty, integrity, quiet resistance, respectful looking—leads gently to the recognition of life's inherent transience, the shadow play described by Omar Khayyám. The body, illuminated briefly by life's candle, casts shadows that flicker softly across walls. Beingness drifts quietly through moments we never fully grasp. In bodyTime(), nothing is claimed or fixed—only gently offered, fleetingly held. It's a humble recognition that the map we've drawn—this essay, these photographs—is not the territory itself. And, every map is a territory—provisional, fraught, incomplete, but real enough to feel and explore.

My role as an artist, facilitator, and photographer is intentionally minimal, a "light-touch" process. I don't direct; I gently invite. I create spaces, not outcomes, because outcomes are never fully ours to control. We strive quietly, humbly, sometimes successfully, sometimes falling short—but the artistry lies in this honest striving. It's not perfection we seek, but the gentle courage to say yes, to take our own power without imposing upon others.

Ultimately, bodyTime() doesn't promise certainty—only possibility. It's an invitation to stand quietly in our authenticity, gently claim our own power, accept vulnerability, reject drama, and embrace integrity. It reminds us softly that we are transient, shadows briefly cast upon a wall, phantom spirits quietly illuminated, each for a brief moment.

In the end, perhaps all we can truly offer is this quiet yes—a soft, humble invitation to meet each other honestly, vulnerably, briefly, before the candle dims and shadows fade. To gently claim our own power, no more, no less. To stand simply as we are—openly, gently, authentically—together.

And then, quietly, let go.